Craft heritage and digital documentation:
the research project Contemporary Authentic

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http://archivio.contemporaryauthentic.com/

Abstract: This project presentation sums up the objective and methodology of documentation of the endangered craft knowledge of some Milanese masters during the two-year research project "Contemporary Authentic". Craft knowledge and skills, like traditions and behaviors, can be considered a form of intangible cultural heritage, defined here as "typical knowledge". Even if craft appears physically in objects or products, it has an immaterial form whose visibility is critical: it's often easier to save the physical product of craft, but saving information related to the context, the handcraft abilities and techniques is more complex. The "Contemporary Authentic/Milano" project, developed by the research group "Design for Cultural Heritage of Politecnico di Milano", developed an articulated strategy of "craft documentation and activation" by digital technologies: video narration, on line repository, mobile app etc… enabling a distributed access to the digital archive and an enriched smart fruition in the context of Expo 2015. This paper illustrates and discusses the results. The findings of the projects (visualisation tools and media, identity system, touristic itineraries) are re-applicable in other similar contexts and are innovative because the go beyond the state of art, establishing a systematic approach, that works both on documentation and fruition of craf.

Keywords: craft heritage, design, activation, video-narration, smart app

Contemporary Authentic: an overview of the project and the initial outcomes

The "Contemporary Authentic/Milano" project, developed by the research group Design for Cultural Heritage of Politecnico di Milano, aims to develop an articulated strategy of "craft activation". This strategy aims to reproduce and transmit cultural heritage through a sustainable process where the authentic qualities are "activated" in the contemporary context by re-contextualising and reviving them in diverse levels (from documentation to transmission, from fruition to use). The creation of the Contemporary Authentic brand is grounded on an investigation into the endangered intangible heritage of Milanese craftsmanship. This heritage represents different forms of knowledge (defined as performative and productive knowledge, Lupo 2008). The project seeks to acknowledge their technical and productive skills, and re-use their procedural, relational, performative qualities, size and spatial impact, through the creation of a complex system of promotion and dissemination.

Contemporary Authentic promotes a shift from the simple representation and elicitation of knowledge to the innovative reproduction of intangible heritage. It focuses on replicable modalities of incorporation of those cultural legacies in the contemporary context, thus insisting on the "use value" of the cultural assets, considered as "open-ended knowledge systems". It also recognizes and supports the territory of the craftsmanship. Starting from a documentation action aimed at both the safeguarding and the understanding of typical Milanese identity features through the development of a web based visual and multimedia catalogue (or repertory) of the masters and their knowledge ("the endangered Master list"), the project has created a system of diffused events and workshops with the aim of both celebrating the masters and helping them establish new relations and innovative re-contextualisation of their knowledge in a contemporary system (through pilot actions called "botteghe" and "convivia").

There are various facets to this research. The creation of the 'Master-Knowledge system model' is a visual tool for collecting the qualities of the typical knowledge 'owned' by a single Master, representing his activation dynamics. Knowledge and practice are detailed in the repertory of good practices of craft knowledge activation. The Endangered Milanese Masters list is a list of 'endangered' Milanese masters, collected according to specific selection criteria and documented on a visual basis, in order to refer to them for further validation and activation activities (http://archivio.contemporaryauthentic.com/masters/). This has constructed the base of new craft activation activities, identifying the dynamics of knowledge sharing, socialization, and communication within the territorial dimension. This list is derived from an initial list of more than 80 masters, that have been contacted or visited for a first evaluation, only 15 have been selected for close observation.

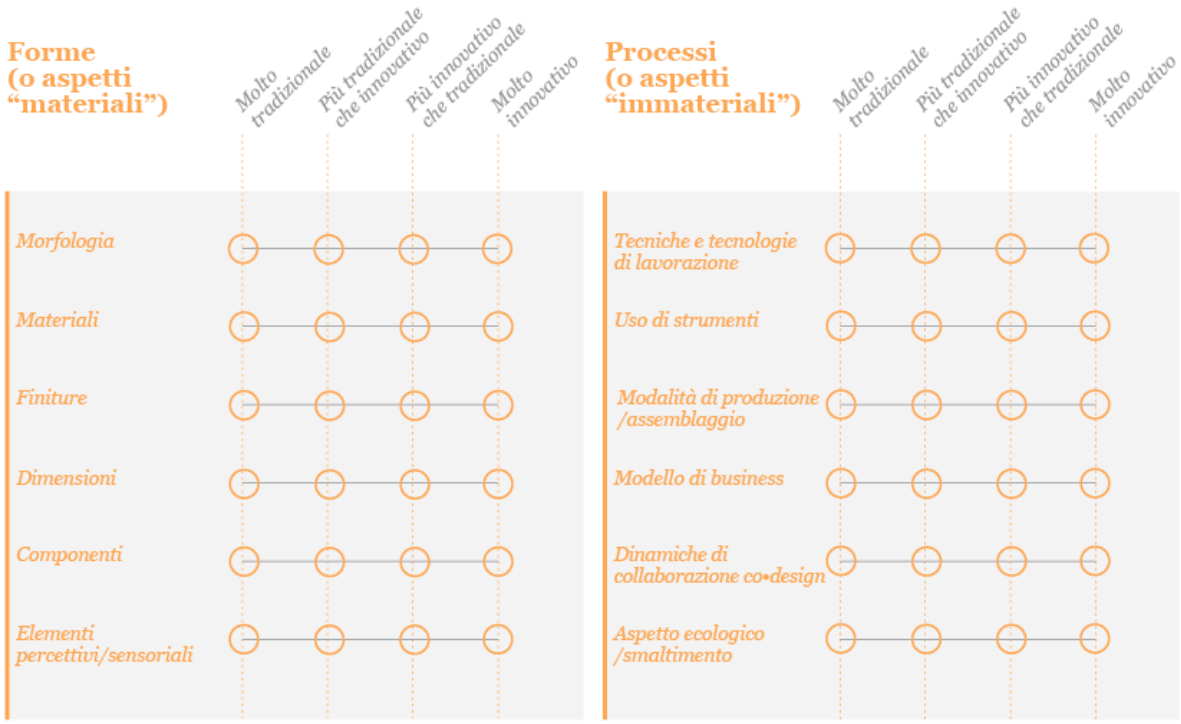
This research is specifically focused on methods of transferring practices in a "formative-educational situation", historically defined as learning by "apprenticeship". These masters practices were "observed" through methods such as "video narration" as an analytical and interpretative inquiry to

explicate and depict the masters and their knowledge. With this video narration method, the objective is to document the master and his story as a portrait. The context where he works is viewed from close up, in the atelier; and from a distance, in the district or city where he works. The modality and potentialities of the re-production and transmission of his knowledge are considered. Short video-documentaries have been produced for 3 masters who have been considered relevant to all the selection parameters. These explore and visually articulate processes concerning typical craft knowledge as an emblematic form of contemporary 'intangible heritage'. It is possible to find all documentaries on line, in the initial prototype of the digital repository.

As mentioned previously, Contemporary Authentic also triggered three "simulate" workshops as productive activities in a teaching incubator. The masters worked for a week with a small group of apprentice design students in Milan, simulating the model of the renaissance workshop called "bottega".

The first goal of this action-research activity, addressing knowledge sharing with the transmission and production system, was to support a new dialogical form of contact between masters and students, craft and design, heritage and innovation, based on mutual respect and a learning-by-doing approach. The second goal was to design new and innovative contemporary authentic products and processes based on heritage. Nine new design concepts have been developed: they exemplify different approaches adopted in order to innovate peculiar aspects of craft knowledge. The design concepts achieve results that go beyond the dichotomy of the material/formal and immaterial/process-driven aspects of the innovation matrix that the project adopted for the craft authenticity evaluation.

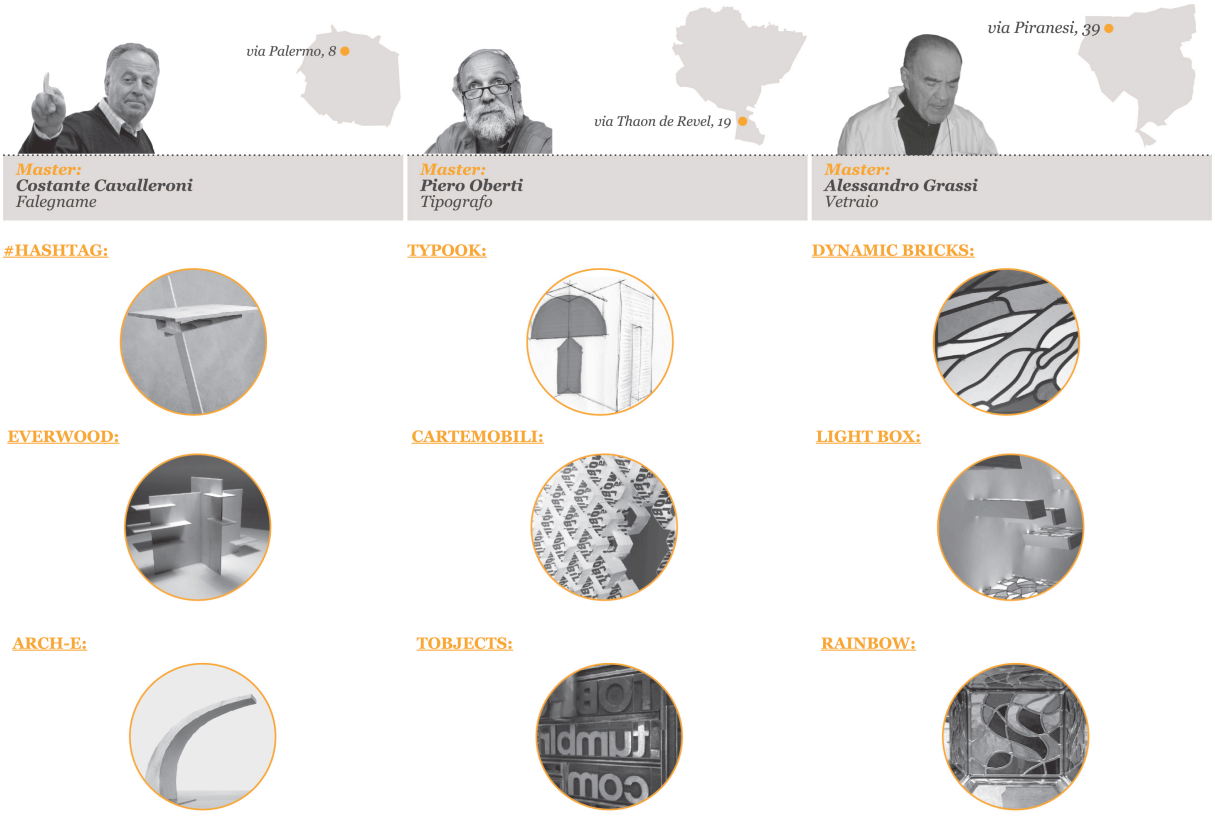
Image 01: Authenticity/innovation evaluation matrix (E. Lupo)



Source: http://contemporaryauthentic.com

They envision changes (or innovation) of typology, product sector and ambit of application of craft: i.e. transfer of knowledge from typographical printing to portable lamps or temporary exhibition design; from glass windows to lamps and furniture; innovation of business model (on line communication and promotion, co-creation with end users); and innovation of production process (usage of waste material, different use of tools, imperfections and finishing).

Image 02: Concepts catalogue (designed by O. Mangiante)



(Source: http://archivio.contemporaryauthentic.com/catalogo/)

The second action-research activity, called “conviva”, addressing knowledge sharing with the wider community system, has been conceived as a public symposia, where the two formats called “craft dialogues” and “craft shows” have been tested, addressing different targets like experts, stake-holders and the general public. The first format, “craft dialogues” were panels of discussions to support dialogue between masters, academics, designers foundations and craft associations. The aim was to explore the limits and potential of the current state of art. The second format, named “craft shows”, were live performances and curatorial exhibitions, with the aim of promoting, disseminating and making known to the general public the contemporariness and liveliness of craft. The first prototype of “convivial” was held on the 18th of May 2013 at the Spazio MIL, Museo Industria e Lavoro e Archivio Giovanni Sacchi in Milano.

At the end of this phase an on-line database (http://archivio.contemporaryauthentic.com/) has been designed to make accessible all the research outcomes. This includes visual and narrative documentation of the transmission of master craft practices and techniques, best practices and the concept catalogue. This on-line database provides the public with a permanent narrative and polyphonic information system about Milanese masters.

Image 03: Online Repository (designed by O. Mangiante)

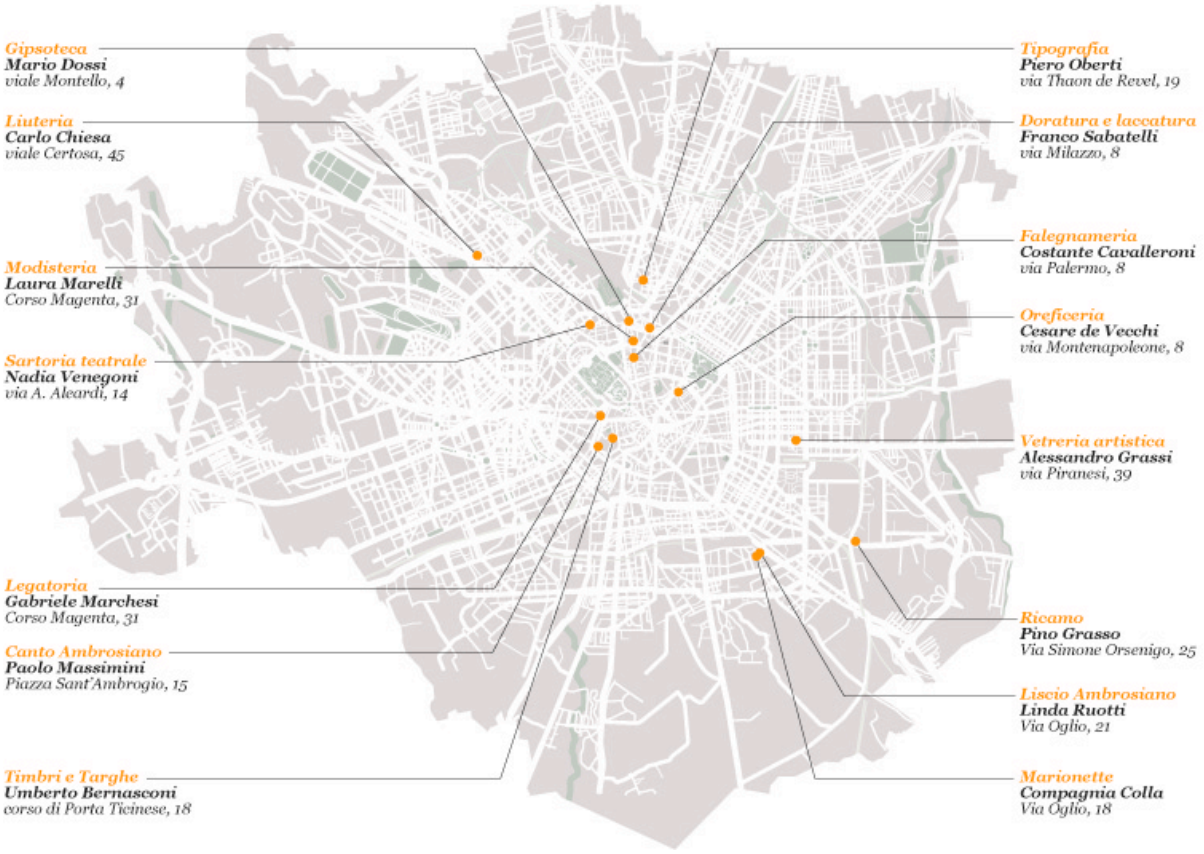


Source: http://contemporaryauthentic.com

Evaluation of impact for further development

According to the Contemporary Authentic strategy, framework and protocol, “craft activations” are designed to innovate technical and productive processes but are nurtured by heritage to maintain authenticity. Digital technologies can play an important role not only in the development of new productive processes but also in the creation of opportunities of cultural experiences about craft, i.e. establishing a “smart” diffused system and platform of visualization, narration, sharing and collaboration of the craft heritage activation. This enables augmented in-place experiences of the craft intelligence of a territory, shaping an intangible geography of cultural contents superimposed on the physical reality. The craft itineraries, already developed in their physical form, are the basis for the development, at this stage under production, of a digital itinerary accessible by apps for smart phones and devices.

Image 04: Craft itineraries (designed by E. Özdil)



Source: http://archivio.contemporaryauthentic.com

As digital communication technologies create easier access, in the context of craft heritage knowledge, not only knowledge activation but also user activation (as in the case of an ubiquitous explorer, learner and collaborator) can lead to a potential development where digital information exchange creates a social environment where users are connected and active through documentation and development. We believe that the shift from a digital archive as information visualization, towards a digital platform of ubiquitous information access and a digital field of collaboration will enable a more sustainable solution for future developments. A potential future development is presented in the next section:

First experiments for further development: CA smart application

This section describes insights for further developments and activities in the Contemporary Authentic project. This first experiment will form the foundation for the “smart” ubiquitous-mobile solution direction that is going to be continuously explored. The Contemporary Authentic brand is considering extending its information access to improve craft heritage activation processes through creating new content and opportunities of collaborations between the masters and the society (clients, visitors…) by digital apps.

For the initial development, we have focused on determining basic features of mobile development with a specific focus on a social layer, or “user” activation. This experiment is based on a previous framework, smart heritage framework, to explore our hypothesis around the Contemporary Authentic experience.

The following list shows our starting points for the new experience:

a. Discovery section: A serendipitous discovery across different content sources; from master’s backgrounds to location information and personalized journeys.

b. Action section: An improvement on how users interact with content, offering them a platform to share information and contribute the digital archive.

c. Collaboration section: From digital-social environment to real time “bottega” collaboration.

Using this feature list, we have translated our goals, initial hypothesis and ideas into experience pillars and design directions. Our aim is to create a live experience in terms of content-knowledge activation and a dynamic experience in terms of visual design and interaction.

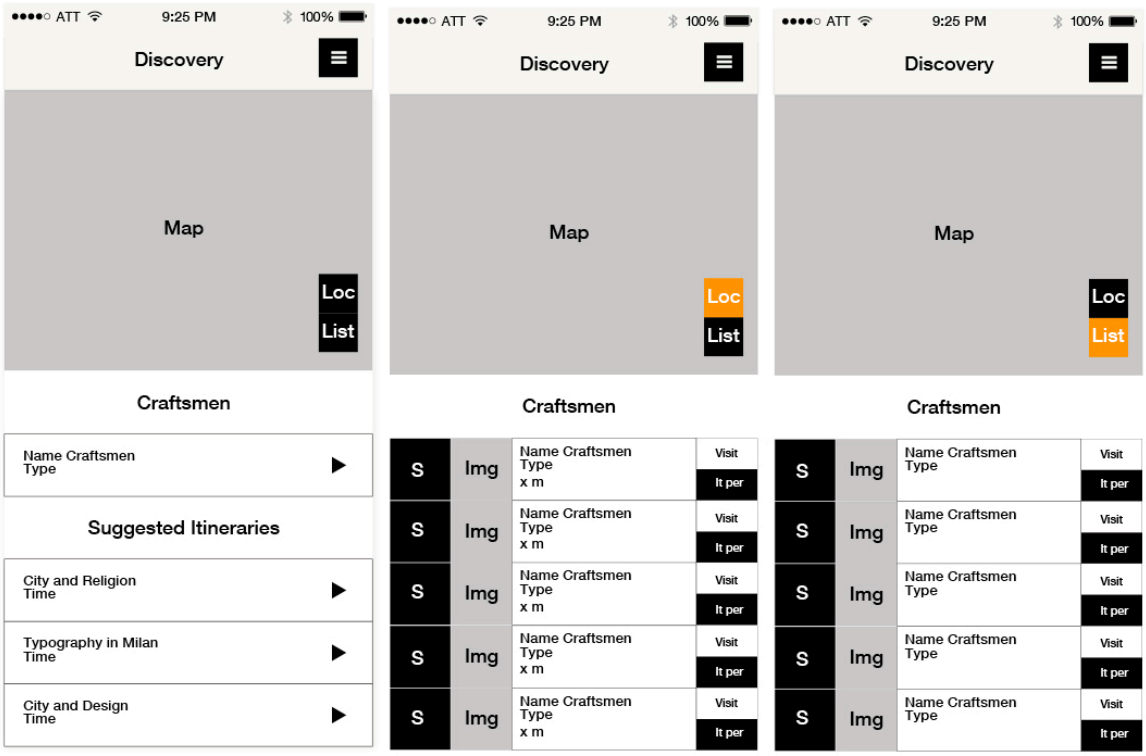
The following pages present some of the key frames of our information architecture:

FTUE - Landing

On FTUE: a small introduction, after splash screens, on what is improved on the new digital mobile experience of the project.

Landing: On the landing page (image 05-a-b-c) you land on the discovery section. This section offers an interactive pinned map where the master’s are represented with a geo-location system, an address and a description of their profession. In this section, there are also additional view options, such as: list view, suggested itineraries, master’s list according to distance and master’s list view in alphabetical order. On this section, you can decide to visit the master, or add him for your personal itinerary.

Image 05: Landing page; a. suggested itineraries, b. location order, c. alphabetical order

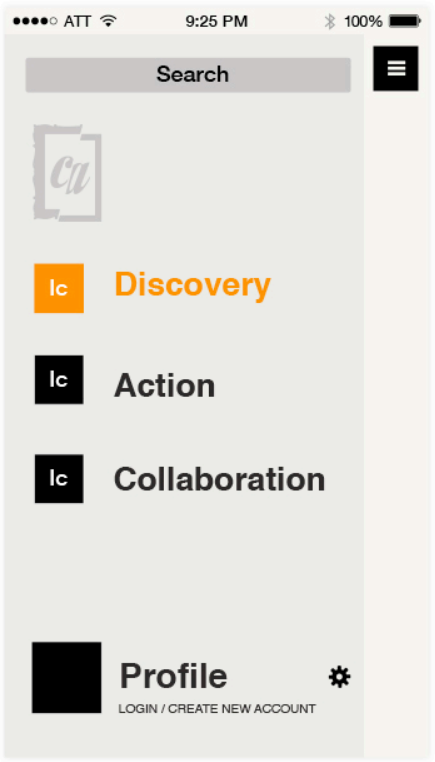


Source: The authors

Menu

Main Menu: image 06 shows the main menu. This allows a manual navigation between sections of the app and surfaces relevant information. The main menu contains the three basic functions of the app: discovery, action and collaboration; in addition to personal profile and settings.

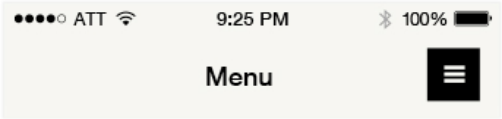
Image 06: Main Menu



Source: The authors

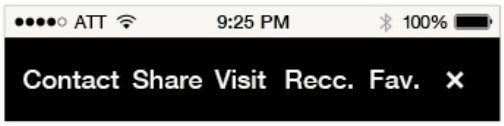
Swipe navigation on top: This internal menu helps you to navigate inside the related page under the main 3 sections.

Image 07: Internal Menu (before swipe)



Source: The authors

Image 08: Internal Menu (after swipe)

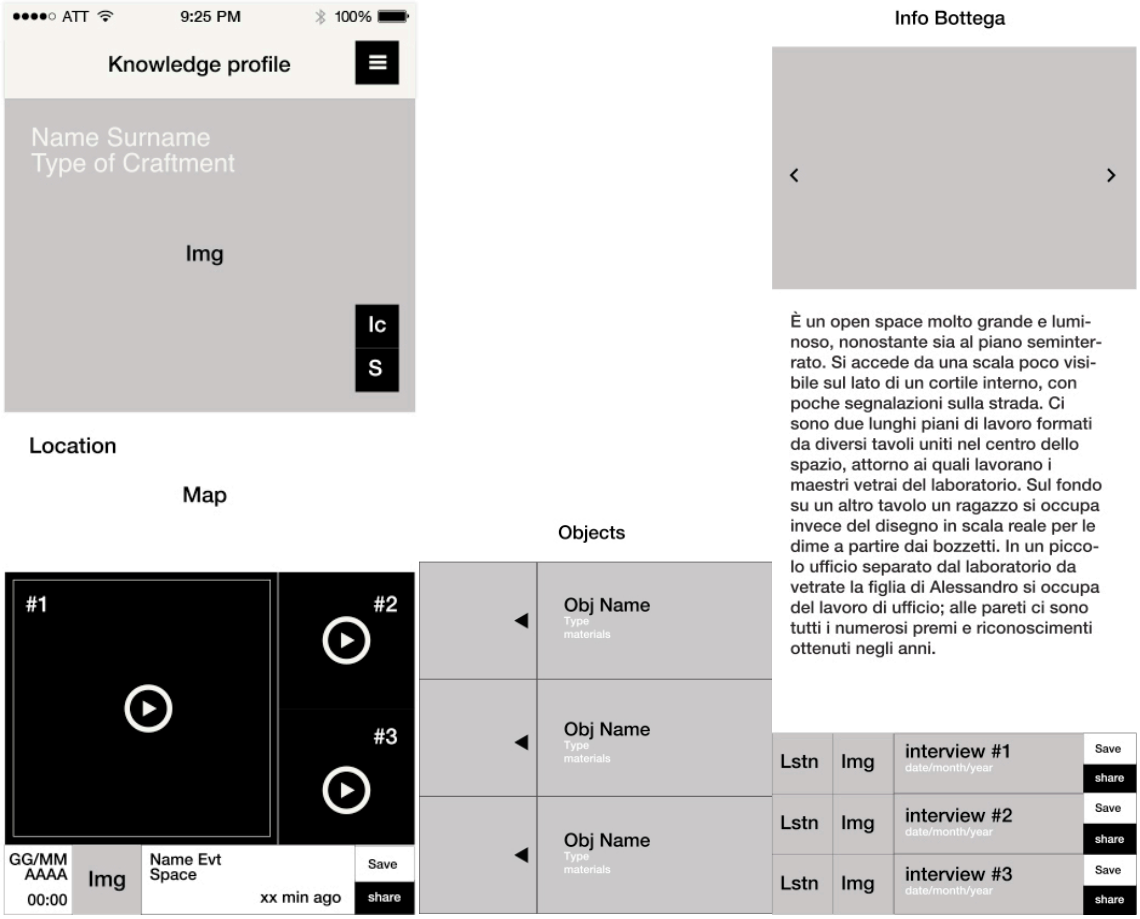


Source: The authors

Craftsmen profile

In image 09, all the background information of the master is presented, with visual support through images, location maps, event notifications, video narratives and bottega descriptions (with images and interviews). Each master is free to present their work. An internal menu serves as a contact bar, where you can do following actions: contact, share, visit, recommend, add to favorites (see also image 05)

Image 09: Craftsmen profile, knowledge profile

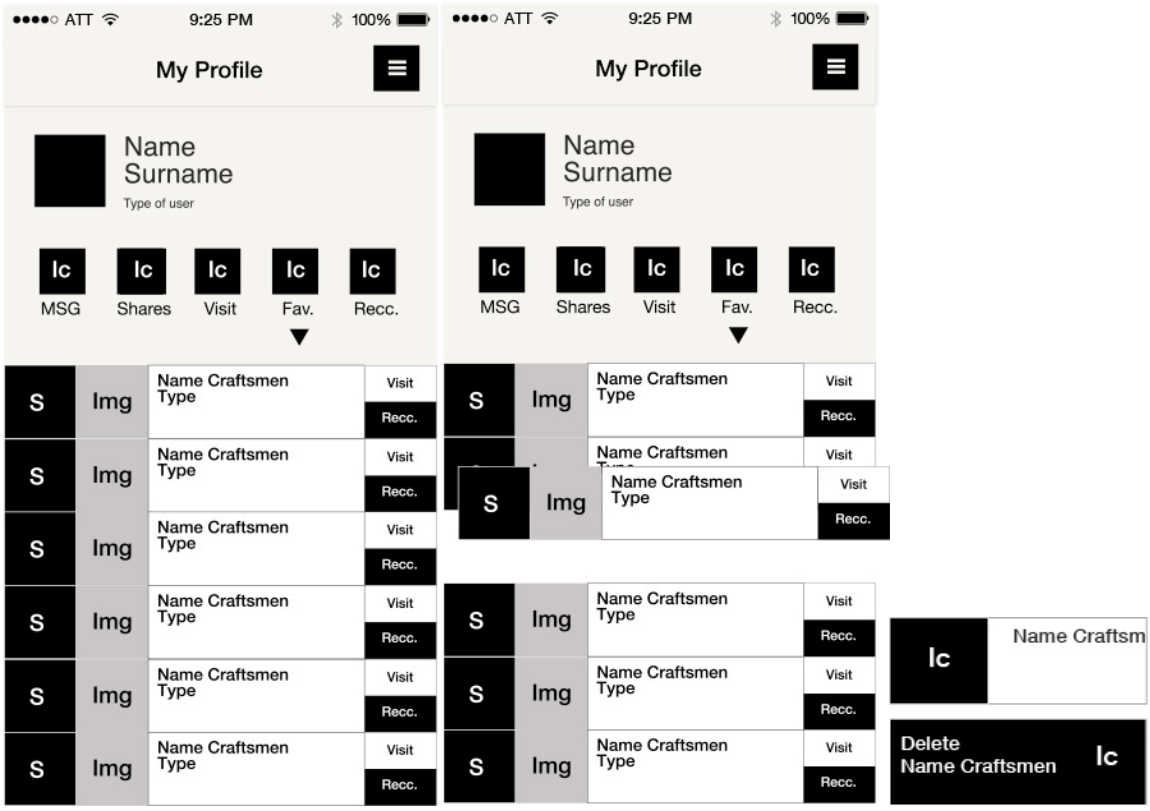


Source: The authors

User profile

As users (explorers and learners) are the main actors, there are dedicated sections for them in the app. These include profiles where they can share their personal information and their activity information. The user can see their activity history on their personal profile, and can select the favorites list and related interaction (see image 10).

Image 10: User profile and additional interaction details.



Source: The authors

Development plan

Here is a scheme on our development phases. Currently we are on the third phase, where we work on key wireframes for starting the visual design exploration.



After the validation on a visual design exploration a design freeze is expected. We have foreseen an incremental development considering user testing to reach the final detailed design for iOs and android. The detailed framework design will be presented during the conference, as we consider it an important review of our development.

Credits

The paper is the result of a collaborative work; anyway Eleonora Lupo edited paragraph 1, while Ece Özdil paragraphs 2 and 3.

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